

Life In A USB Nutshell

Must we really wait a few more years for anytime access to our applications?

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To most people, computing on the go means investing in a laptop, PDA, smart-phone, or any such mobile device that lets one carry one's data and applications along with them. This is all very well for big corporates who can afford it, but what of the common businessman? In a SoHo or Small Business, you can't really be expected to buy a company laptop for everyone who needs it and not feel the pinch, can you?

The ultimate solution to this problem will be on-demand computing—when we'd sit in front of any PC, anywhere, and with the digital equivalent of yelling "Gimme!", have all our applications and data at our beck and call. Of course, there's still a few years to go before that.

But strangely enough, most of us don't even realise that we *don't* need to wait for the advent of on-demand computing—we've got the solution to these woes in our hands already! Many people carry their data around on a USB stick—presentations, documents, spreadsheets, you name it—why not carry programs too? Portable Applications are built for the sole purpose of being run off a USB stick—no installation, no

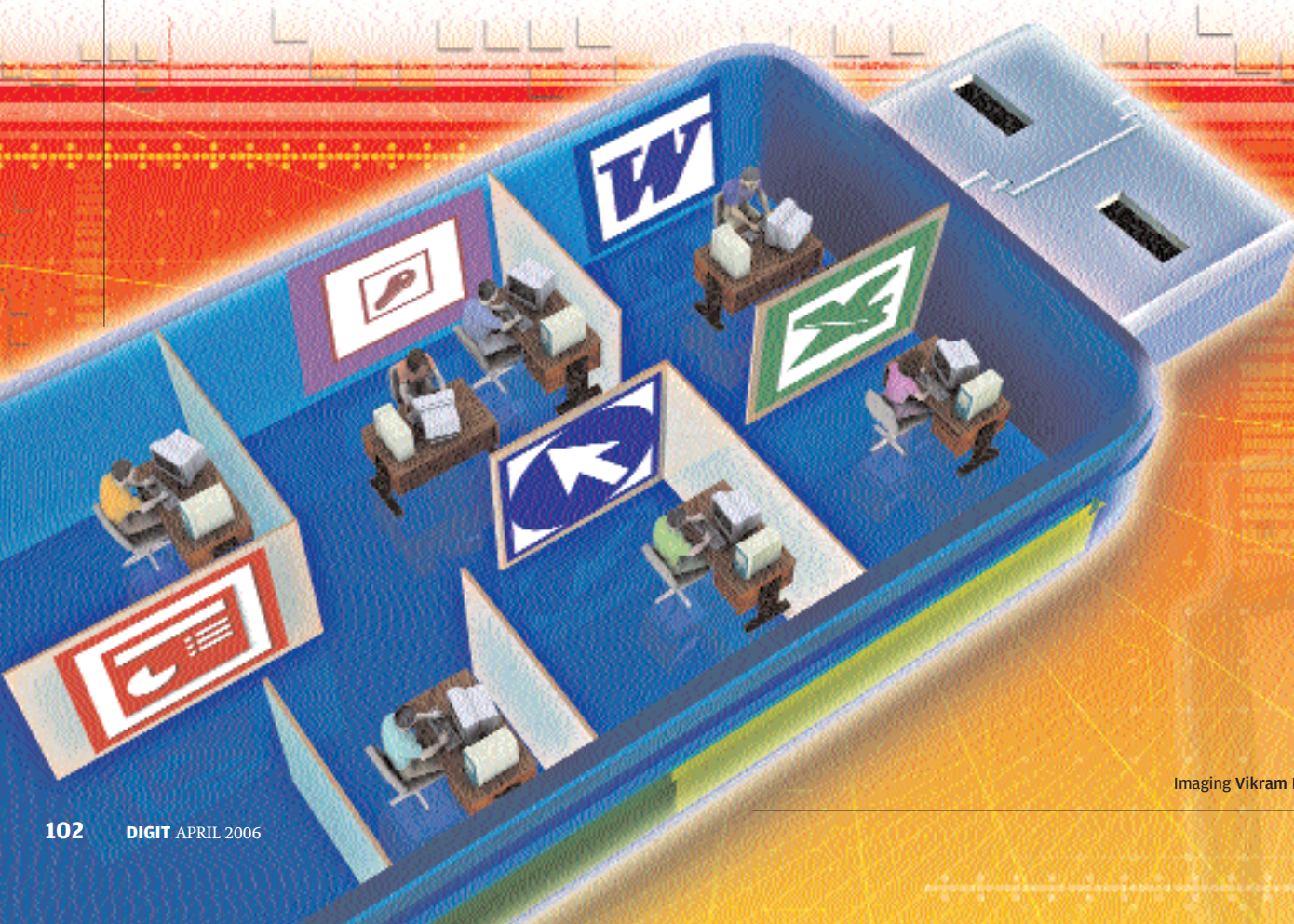
writing settings to anything other than its own folder, and best of all, nearly all of them are free.

All you'd need then would be access to any PC with a USB hub, and you've saved yourself at least Rs 20,000!

The Demands

Finding the best portable application for your needs is all about balancing size and features. Your first consideration is that the application should not write any settings to the host computer—you don't really want to leave your mark anywhere. The next priority is size—you'd rather have several small programs rather than one that hogs all the space. After all, even 512 MB USB drives can get full alarmingly quickly, and the more room you have for our data, the better. Smaller applications do tend to have fewer features, but let's admit it—few of us use *all* the bells and whistles in most software anyway.

So it's decided: you go out and buy a 512 MB USB drive (this will cost you about Rs 1,650). You should remember, however, that all the applications need to be crammed into 200 MB of space—the remaining 300-odd should be kept free for data. Small size is a priority, but as far as possible, you don't want to compromise on features. You also have to take into consideration the



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